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Subject-Verb Agreement • ENGLISH I

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Subject

Verb

□ Subject-Verb Agreement:

- The subject and verb are the most important elements of a sentence. The relation between the subject and verb depends on two issues: **person and number**. The verb of a sentence must be in agreement with the subject in regard to person and number.

The number of the subject can be **singular** and **plural**. The **verb must be singular if the subject is singular** and the **verb must be plural if the subject is plural**. So, **identifying the number of the subject is required to take a verb**.

The person of the subject can be **first**, **second**, and **third**. The verb changes according to the number and person of the subject.

- Here are some rules of Subject-Verb Agreement in English, which you should definitely master:
1. Singular subjects need singular verbs, while plural subjects require plural verbs. **‘Be’ verbs change the most according to the number and person of the subject**. Other verbs do not change much on the basis of the subjects **except the verbs of the Present Indefinite Tense**. If the subjects are a third person singular number, the verbs are used with s/es when they are in **Present Indefinite Tense**. *The verbs with s/es in the sentence are called singular verbs.* **‘Be’ verbs according to number and person of the subject.**

Person/Number	Singular	Plural
First	am	are
Second	are	are
Third	is	are

Example:

Person/Number	Singular	Plural
First	I <u>am</u> an excellent tennis player.	We <u>are</u> excellent tennis players.
Second	You <u>are</u> a nice person.	You all <u>are</u> nice people.
Third	He <u>is</u> good at playing baseball.	They <u>are</u> good at chasing.

2. When the prepositional phrases separate the subjects from the verbs, they have **no effect on the verbs**.

Examples:

- ✓ A study (singular subject) on African countries shows (singular verb) that 80% of the people (plural subject) of this continent live (plural verb) below the poverty line.
- ✓ The perspective of different people varies from time to time.
- ✓ The fear of terrorists and militants has made them flee from the city.

3. Nouns, connected by the conjunction 'and' in the subject, work as the **plural subject** and **take a plural verb**.

Examples:

- ✓ Akib and Shamim are coming here.
- ✓ Robin and his friends want to go on a tour.

4. If the conjunction 'and' is replaced by 'together with', 'along with', 'accompanied by', 'as well as', the verb will have no effect for the later part of these expressions. The **words prior to these expressions are the subjects**.

Examples:

- ✓ Tamim, along with his brothers, is going to the city. (*'His brothers' is not the subject of this sentence.*)
- ✓ Aman, as well as his parents, is coming to the party.

NB: *If these expressions are replaced by 'and', the subjects will be regarded as plurals, and so the verbs have to be plural. (Rule 3)*

5. **Some nouns are always singular and indefinite**. When these nouns become the subjects, **they always take singular verbs**. These nouns are:

Any + singular noun	No + singular noun	Some + sin. noun	Every + sin. noun	Each + sin. noun
Anybody	Nobody	Somebody	Everybody	Each
Anyone	No one	Someone	Everyone	Either*
Anything	Nothing	Something	Everything	Neither*

★ **NB:** *'Either' and 'neither' are singular if they are not used with 'or' and 'nor'.*

Examples:

- ✓ Everybody wants to live happily.
- ✓ Neither of you is responsible enough to handle it.
- ✓ Each student has to submit a separate assignment.

6. **Some nouns are always plural**. You can identify these nouns easily as these nouns have two parts. For example: **scissors, shorts, eyeglasses, pants, thongs, jeans, trousers, etc.**

Examples:

- ✓ Your pants are in the drawer.
- ✓ His eyeglasses are dirty.
- ✓ These scissors are useless.

NB: If these words are preceded by the phrase “**a pair of**”, they will be regarded as singular subjects. For example:

- ✓ A pair of jeans **is** needed.
- ✓ This pair of trousers **is** ugly.

7. Subjects that are singular in meaning but plural in a form, such as **poetry, news, politics, information, economics, scenery, advice, furniture, wages, etc.**, have **singular verbs**.

Example:

- ✓ The news **is** spreading fast.

8. **None** is a **singular subject when it is used alone**. When it is used with a prepositional phrase starting with “of”, the **subject can be both plural and singular**.

- *None + of the + singular noun + singular verb*
- *None + of the + plural noun + plural verb*

Examples:

- ✓ None of the money **has** been used.
- ✓ None of the teacher **wants** failure for students.
- ✓ None of the students **want** to fail.

NB: “*No + plural noun*” takes *plural verbs*. For example:

- ✓ No men **are** hungry now.

9. ‘**Either . . . or**’, ‘**neither . . . nor**’, ‘**or**’, and ‘**nor**’ take two nouns before and after them. The nouns **placed after these conjunctions are regarded as the subjects of the sentence**. The nouns placed prior to the words ‘or’ and ‘nor’ have no effect on the verbs.

Examples:

- ✓ Neither Aman nor his brothers **are** going to the party.
- ✓ Either Jim and Ali or I **am** doing it.
- ✓ I or Robin **opens** the door when someone comes.

10. The sentences beginning with **here/there** are different in structure. In this case, **the subject comes after the verb**.

- *Here/There + verb + subject*

Examples:

- ✓ Here comes (verb) the lion (subject).
- ✓ There **is** a pond near the house.
- ✓ There **are** some candies on the table.

11. **Collective nouns** are usually regarded as **singular subjects**.

Examples:

- ✓ The committee **has** decided to postpone the game.
- ✓ The family **was** ecstatic by the news.
- ✓ The crowd **enjoys** the excitement in the game.

NB: The following phrases are also regarded as collective nouns and thus singular subjects: *flock of birds/sheep, herd of cattle, pack of dogs/wolves, school of fish, pride of lions*

Examples:

- ✓ A flock of sheep always **moves** together.
- ✓ A pack of wolves **is** approaching towards the herd of cattle.

12. “A number of + noun” is a plural subject, and it takes a plural verb. “The number of + noun” is a singular subject, and it takes a singular verb.

Examples:

- ✓ A number of dancers **are** coming to the party. (*Indefinite number of dancers – plural*)
- ✓ The number of dancers coming to the party **is** 12. (*Definite number of dancers – singular*)
- ✓ A number of people **prefer** cricket to football.
- ✓ The number of days in this month **is** 28.

13. If a gerund or an infinitive comes as a subject, the verb will always be singular.

Examples:

- ✓ Walking **is** a good habit.
- ✓ Eating healthy food **makes** you healthy.
- ✓ To err **is** human.

14. If “the + an adjective” appears as the subject of a sentence, the verb will be plural.

Examples:

- ✓ The pious **are** loved by God.
- ✓ The industrious **are** always not successful.

15. If a sentence contains “No sooner had than”, “Scarcely had when”, “Hardly had when/before”, then the first verb will be in the past participle and the second verb will be in the past form.

Examples:

- ✓ No sooner **had** the thief **seen** the police **than** he **ran** away.
- ✓ Scarcely **had** I **reached** the station **when** the train **left**.

16. The connector “since” has two usages.

- If since is used to **indicate a cause**, the **verbs of the two clauses will be of the same tense**.

Examples:

- ✓ I **didn't** go **since** you **didn't** come.
- ✓ **Since** you **were** busy, I **didn't** disturb you.
- If since is used to **indicate time**, the **verb of the second clause will be different from the first**.

Examples:

- ✓ We haven't seen (present perfect) each other since he left (past indefinite).
- ✓ It has been 20 years since he played football.
- ✓ 20 years passed (past indefinite) since we had met (past perfect).

17. The main verb after 'to be' and 'having' takes past participle form.

Example:

- ✓ He ran away having taken the money.

18. If the verb –

- comes after "while", then the verb will take 'ing' with it.
- comes after "while + subject", then the verb will be in the Past Continuous Tense.

Examples:

- ✓ While going to school, I saw a snake.
- ✓ While he was playing football, I finished organizing this room.

19. If a sentence contains 'had rather', 'had better', 'would better', 'let', 'would rather', 'dare', 'must need', etc, then –

- The verb is in the present form.
- If there is 'to' before that verb, the 'to' will be omitted.

Example:

- ✓ You had better go to the class.

20. The phrase 'it is time' or 'it is high time' requires a verb in the past form or infinitive verb if there is a clause after it.

- It is high time + subject + past indefinite.....
- It **was** high time + subject + **past perfect**.....
- It is high time + infinitive.....

Examples:

- ✓ It is high time you studied attentively.
- ✓ It is time to study attentively. (You can replace the clause by an infinitive removing the subject)
- ✓ It was high time we had returned home. ("It was high time" requires past perfect tense).

21. If the first part of 'as though/as if' is present indefinite, then the next part will be past indefinite. If the first part is past indefinite, the next part will be past perfect.

Examples:

- ✓ He speaks as though he knew everything.
- ✓ He behaved as if he had gone mad.

22. After 'as though', 'as if', 'wish', the 'to be verb' transforms into 'were'.

Examples:

- ✓ I wish I **were** a butterfly.
- ✓ She talked as though she **were** a queen.

23. After phrases such as ‘**get used to**’, ‘**without**’, ‘**cannot/could not help**’, ‘**with a view to/toward**’, ‘**look forward to**’, ‘**would you mind**’, etc., the given verb takes ‘**ing**’ form.

Example:

- ✓ I went to Chittagong with a view to **attending** my friend’s wedding.

24. With ‘**lest**’ in the sentence, ‘**might/should**’ follows the subject.

Examples:

- ✓ He worked hard lest he **might** miss the deadline.
- ✓ She left early lest he **should** miss the bus.

25. For sentences starting with ‘**would that**’, there comes a ‘**could**’ after the subject and the verb is in present form.

Example:

- ✓ Would that I **could see** a lion.

26. If interrogative sentences start with **who, which, what, where**, etc., then there comes an auxiliary verb according to tense and person.

Example:

- ✓ Where **had** you been since yesterday?

27. In the case of **uncountable nouns**, such as oxygen, water, air, etc., the verb takes a singular form.

Example:

- ✓ Water **is** necessary for living.

28. **Coordinating conjunctions** (*and, but, or, yet, so*) and **although/though, as, because, till/until, when, whenever, as soon as, while, which, what, that**, etc. connect two clauses which have the verbs of the same tense.

Examples:

- ✓ We **went** to Khulna when we **were** young.
- ✓ As soon as I **came** here, you all **greeted** me.

29. The base form of the verb is also used in the clauses that **use the subjunctive mood**. “**Some certain verbs + the conjunction**” that requires the **next clause** to use the **subjunctive mood** and the clause uses the base form of the verb in it.

These verbs are:

- ⇒ **advise, demand, prefer, require, ask, insist, propose, stipulate, command, recommend, suggest, decree, order, request, urge, move**

Structure: *Subject + the verbs mentioned above (any tense) + **THAT** + subject + base verb +*

Examples:

- ✓ He **insisted** that I **stay** at home.
- ✓ The office **requires** that we **complete** our work timely.
- ✓ She **commanded** that he **stop** making excuses for being late.

NB: *There are some clauses also which require the verb of the next clause to be in base form. These clauses are:*

- *It is/was + past participle form of the verb of the above box + **THAT***
- *It is/was urgent + **THAT***
- *It is/was necessary + **THAT***
- *It is/was important + **THAT***

Examples:

- ✓ It is important that you **invite** him.
- ✓ It was necessary that I **make** a fence.
- ✓ It was recommended that you **meet** the principal.

NOW CHILLAX 😊